the front, had a higher death rate than any other group. The attitude of ordinary soldiers to their officers varied depending on personal factors, but respect was more common than hostility, despite an inevitable social class divide. The working class predominated in the ranks and set the tone for the ordinary soldier, even though many individuals of higher social standing dutifully served as privates. Officers were generally from the middle or upper class. At the start of the war, men from a public school background were able to step straight into commissions on the grounds of having served in their school cadet corps. This did not, of course, mean that they were necessarily poor officers or out of touch with the experience of their men, though some were both. Yet promotion from the ranks was in fact not unknown even in the prewar British army – the head of the Imperial General Staff, Field Marshal Sir William Robertson, had started his army career as a private. From 1916 onwards the majority of newly commissioned officers were men who had served in the ranks.



A war of attrition
Between late 1914 and the summer of 1916, the front line barely moved. Even after that, as the Allies gradually wore down German resistance, progress was painfully slow. At the Armistice in November 1918 the Germans still occupied most of Belgium and significant areas of France.

DISCIPLINE AND PUNISHMENT

The strains of trench life inevitably led to disciplinary problems. The odd foray by British soldiers into French villages often resulted in drunkenness and disorder; although the men had little money to spend on their pleasures, many of them still managed to contract venereal diseases. As well as drunkenness, common forms of indiscipline leading to punishment included insolence to a superior and various forms of sloppiness in dress or conduct. In some of the more traditionalist regiments officers and NCOs were especially punctilious about minor regulations, but the excessive enforcement of such rules could attract adverse attention from the press – as when the court martial of a young officer for shaving off his moustache was quashed after a public outcry. Although flogging had long been abolished, there were brutal old-fashioned army punishments – such as being tied to the wheel of a heavy artillery piece for public humiliation – that were still administered. Many soldiers objected to such practices as inappropriate for a citizen-army. For the gravest offences, such as striking an officer and desertion, the death penalty was available. It was rarely applied, some 260 men being executed for military crimes, mostly for desertion, in the course of the war.

Occupying a captured trench
Moments like this when men could relax after a successful advance were rare. The trench now had to be refortified quickly in preparation for the inevitable German counterattack.

